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Tehillim 25: To You I Lift My Soul

An excerpt for LinkedIn: the introduction and Chapter One, “To You I Lift My Soul” (verse 1). The full study booklet runs to 96 pages.

אֵלֶיךָ ה' נַפְשִׁי אֶשָּׂא

Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren

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Prepared on Wednesday, 11 November 2026 (1 Kislev 5787, the second day of Rosh Chodesh Kislev), Jerusalem, in the week of Parashas Toldos.
Not for sale. For study at the table, in the beis midrash and at home.

Prepared in deep partnership and cooperation with Grok and xAI

A note on sources

This LinkedIn excerpt contains only the introduction, Chapter One, and Appendix A (Tehillim 25 in full). The other chapters, and the other appendices named in the introduction, are in the full 96-page booklet, not in this file.

Every Hebrew quotation in this booklet was cut directly from the text as opened on Sefaria on 11 November 2026, with vowels and cantillation removed. Verses from Tanach are given in the English of *Tanakh: The Holy Scriptures* (Jewish Publication Society, 1985), as published on Sefaria. All other translations are my own working translations, made against the Hebrew printed beside them; where words are omitted from a long comment, the source line says so. The edition used for each text is listed in the Bibliography.

Divine Names. In English this booklet writes G-d, L-rd and Hashem. In Hebrew the Tetragrammaton and the short two-letter Name are printed as ה', and the name Elokim as אלקים. No Divine Name is printed in full.

Sources and limits. Every teaching in this booklet comes from a classical text opened for it: the Mishnah, the Talmud Bavli, *Midrash Tehillim*, Rashi, Radak, Ibn Ezra, the Metzudas David and the Malbim. No secondary or web source is quoted. The custom in some communities of saying Tehillim 25 in Tachanun is not discussed, since I could not open a siddur text for it this time.

Care in speech. The psalm speaks of enemies who hate without cause. This booklet keeps to the applications of the commentators, and applies their words to no living person, party or government.

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INTRODUCTION

A Psalm of Letters

The alphabet, the verse beyond it, and three threads to the week

Tehillim 25 is a prayer arranged on the alphabet, with one verse added after the last letter. This introduction reads Radak on the form, and sets out the threads of trust, the way, and Toldos.

A psalm of letters

Tehillim 25 is a prayer arranged on the Hebrew alphabet. Each verse, more or less, begins with the next letter: alef, beis, gimmel, and on. Radak, opening his commentary, notes the form and admits what we do not know about it.

> לדוד זה המזמור נאמר באל"ף בי"ת; וכן יש אחרים בספר כמוהו. ויש אות אחת בראש כל פסוק, ויש שני פסוקים באות אחת, ויש בפסוק אחד שתי אותיות; ולא נודע אצלנו מפני מה באלו יותר מבאחרים אלא אם כן נזדמן לו בפיו ברוח הקדש
>
> *"Of David": this psalm is said in alphabetical order, and there are others in the book like it. Sometimes there is one letter at the head of each verse, sometimes two verses for one letter, and sometimes two letters in one verse. We do not know why in these psalms more than in others, unless it came to his mouth so through the holy spirit.*
>
> Radak on Tehillim 25:1

Radak does not invent a reason. "It came to his mouth so through the holy spirit." The form is there to be noticed, not explained away. A careful reader will see that the pattern is not perfect: a letter or two is missing, and after the tav, the last letter, one more verse is added, beginning with pe: "O G-d, redeem Israel from all its distress." The same thing happens at the end of Tehillim 34, another alphabetical psalm of David.

> פדה ה' נפש עבדיו ולא יאשמו כל־החסים בו
>
> *The L-RD redeems the life of His servants; all who take refuge in Him shall not be ruined. (JPS)*
>
> Tehillim 34:23

Both psalms finish the alphabet, the whole of what a person can say, and then step outside it to pray for redemption. The private prayer is complete; the prayer for the community comes after.

Why this psalm now

This booklet was prepared for this week: Wednesday, 11 November 2026, Rosh Chodesh Kislev 5787, in the week of Parashas Toldos. Three threads run from the psalm to the week.

The first is trust. The second verse is elokai becha vatachti, "My G-d, in You I trust." Kislev is the month of kesel, trust, as the companion booklet on the month explains. The Malbim reads the whole psalm as a prayer whose goal is not getting what one asks for but keeping one's trust intact. That is the inner work of Kislev.

The second is the way. The psalm asks again and again to be shown G-d's ways: "Let me know Your paths," "guide me in Your true way," "He shows sinners the way," "He guides the lowly." A new month is a road. Its first day is a good day to ask for directions.

The third is Toldos. *Midrash Tehillim*, reading verse 19, "See how numerous my enemies are, and how unjustly they hate me," sets David's enemies against Esav: Esav at least had a grievance against Yaakov; David's enemies hated him for nothing. Chapter Seven reads that midrash with this week's parashah.

The commentators

This booklet reads the psalm with Rashi, Radak, Ibn Ezra, the Metzudas David and the Malbim, and with *Midrash Tehillim*, which has much to say about it. The Gemara speaks of verse 8, "He shows sinners the way," in its discussion of the cities of refuge, and that passage is read in Chapter Five.

The order of this booklet

- Chapter One, "To You I Lift My Soul," reads verse 1: the archer's target, the hired labourer, and the soul held in trust.
- Chapter Two, "In You I Trust," reads verses 2 and 3: trust that does not want to be shamed, and the stranger who said, "I am of the king's household."
- Chapter Three, "Let Me Know Your Ways," reads verses 4 and 5: ways and paths, and Moshe's request.
- Chapter Four, "Remember Your Mercies," reads verses 6 and 7: the kindness of creation and the sins of youth.

- Chapter Five, “He Shows Sinners the Way,” reads verses 8 to 10: the signposts to the cities of refuge, and the paths of kindness and truth.
- Chapter Six, “Who Is the Man Who Fears the L-rd?”, reads verses 11 to 14: forgiveness for a great sin, the man who chooses, and the secret of G-d.
- Chapter Seven, “Alone and Afflicted,” reads verses 15 to 19: the net, the widened heart, and the enemies who hate without cause.
- Chapter Eight, “Redeem Israel,” reads verses 20 to 22: integrity as a guard, and the verse beyond the alphabet.

Each chapter ends with questions for the table. The appendices give Tehillim 25 in full, the other alphabetical and trust psalms that echo it, the Thirteen Attributes from Shemos 34, and the commentaries in the original Hebrew.

CHAPTER ONE

To You I Lift My Soul

Verse 1: the archer's mark, the hired labourer, and the soul on deposit

The first verse is the pivot of the psalm. This chapter reads Rashi, Radak, Ibn Ezra, the Metzudas and the Malbim on lifting the soul, and three readings in *Midrash Tehillim*: the hired labourer, the generation of persecution, and the soul held in trust.

Lifting the soul

לדוד אליך ה' נפשי אשא

> *Of David. O L-RD, I set my hope on You; (JPS)*
> Tehillim 25:1

The psalm begins without a heading beyond "of David," and without a word of introduction. Its first sentence is its whole content: "O L-rd, I set my hope on You," in Hebrew eilecha Hashem nafshi essa, literally, "to You, O L-rd, I lift my soul."

The commentators read the phrase in several ways. Rashi gives the briefest.

נפשי אשא. אכון לבי

> *"I set my hope (nafshi essa)": I direct my heart.*
> Rashi on Tehillim 25:1

"I direct my heart." Radak hears supplication, the lifting of hands and heart in prayer.

אליך ה' נפשי אשא: דרך תחנה כמו נשא לבבנו אל כפים

> *"To You, O L-rd, I lift my soul": in the manner of supplication, as in "Let us lift up our hearts with our hands" (Eichah 3:41).*
> Radak on Tehillim 25:1

Ibn Ezra records an earlier view, that the soul is lifted as an offering, and prefers another: the soul is lifted toward G-d as a worker sets his heart on his wage.

אמר רבי משה: טעם נפשי אשא כדרך מנחה כמו: וישא משאות. והנכון בעיני: שהוא כמו: ואליו הוא נושא את נפשו, לא לאחר

Rabbi Moshe [ibn Gikatilla] said: "I lift my soul" is in the manner of an offering, as in "portions were served them" (Bereishis 43:34). But what is correct in my eyes is that it is like "and he sets his heart on it" (Devarim 24:15): [to You,] not to another.

Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 25:1

"To You, not to another." The Metzudas joins the two readings.

נפשי אשא. אמסור נפשי לך למנה

"I lift my soul": I will hand my soul over to You as a gift.

Metzudas David on Tehillim 25:1

"I will hand my soul over to You as a gift." The soul is both the prayer and the offering.

The archer's mark

The Malbim calls this verse the pivot of the psalm.

פסוק זה הוא קוטב המזמור ויסודו, בו יאמר, שכמו שהמורה בחצים ישים לו אות שאליו יורה למטרה, כן שם את ה' לאות ולמטרה אל כל מבוקשיו וחפציו, בין הגשמיים בין הרוחניים, ואמר רק אליך ה' אשא נפשי, אתה עיקר מגמתי לא דבר זולתך, שכל ענייני אתה הוא תכלית מבוקשי, וכל חפצי הם רק אמצעיים להגיע על ידם אל התכלית זה

This verse is the pivot of the psalm and its foundation. In it he says: as an archer sets himself a mark at which to shoot, so he has set Hashem as the mark and target of all his requests and desires, both physical and spiritual. He says: only to You, Hashem, do I lift my soul; You are my chief aim and nothing besides You; in all my affairs You are the goal of what I seek, and all my desires are only means to reach that goal.

Malbim on Tehillim 25:1

An archer chooses a mark and aims everything at it. The psalmist has chosen his mark: G-d. Everything else he asks for, health, safety, livelihood, even wisdom, is a means. The goal is G-d Himself.

This is a demanding idea and a freeing one. It is demanding because it asks a person to examine what he is really aiming at. It is freeing because it means that no request is lost. If the goal is G-d, then even an unanswered request has served its purpose, if it brought the one who asked closer.

The hired labourer

Midrash Tehillim reads the verse through a law in Devarim.

לדוד אליך ה' נפשי אשא. זהו שאמר הכתוב (דברים כד טו) ביומו תתן שכרו. אמר לו הקב"ה לדוד דוד למה אתה נושא נפשך אלי. אמר לו מפני שאני שכיר בעולמך. שנאמר (איוב ז ב) כעבד ישאף צל וכשכיר יקוה פעלו. וכתיב בתורה ביומו תתן שכרו וגו' ואליו הוא נושא את נפשו. אם הפועל הזה שהוא שכירו וחייב ליתן לו כתב ואליו הוא נושא את נפשו. אנו שנפשותינו תלויות בך על אחת כמה וכמה

> *"Of David. To You, O L-rd, I lift my soul." This is what Scripture says, "You must pay him his wages on the same day … for he is needy and he sets his heart (nafsho) on it" (Devarim 24:15). The Holy One, blessed be He, said to David: David, why do you lift your soul to Me? He said to Him: Because I am a hired labourer in Your world, as it says, "Like a slave who longs for the shade, like a hireling who waits for his wage" (Iyov 7:2); and it is written in the Torah, "you must pay him his wages on the same day … and he sets his heart on it." If this labourer, who is his hireling and whom he is obligated to pay, sets his soul on him, we, whose souls depend on You, how much more so!*
>
> Midrash Tehillim 25

ביומו תתן שכרו ולא־תבוא עליו השמש כי עני הוא ואליו הוא נשא את־נפשו ולא־יקרא עליך אל־ה' והיה בך חטא

> *You must pay him his wages on the same day, before the sun sets, for he is needy and urgently depends on it; else he will cry to the L-RD against you and you will incur guilt. (JPS)*
>
> Devarim 24:15

The Torah commands an employer to pay a poor worker on the day he works, "for he is needy and urgently depends on it" (in Hebrew, "he lifts his soul to it"). The Midrash hears the same phrase in our psalm. David says to G-d: I am a hired worker in Your world, and I lift my soul to You as the worker lifts his soul to his wage. If a human employer must not keep a worker waiting, how much more will You not keep me waiting, I whose soul depends on You.

It is a bold image. It does not say that we have earned anything. It says that we are needy, that we have worked, and that the One who commanded us to pay workers on time can be trusted to do the same.

The Midrash then gives a second, darker reading.

דבר אחר אליך ה'. זה דורו של שמד שנתמשכנו על קדושת השם. כענין שנאמר (דברים כד י) כי תשה ברעך משאת מאומה

Another interpretation: "To You, O L-rd": this is the generation of persecution, who gave themselves as a pledge for the sanctification of the Name, as it says, "When you make a loan of any sort to your countryman" (Devarim 24:10).

Midrash Tehillim 25

"The generation of persecution" lifted their souls to G-d in the most literal sense: they gave their lives for the sanctification of His Name. The verse that the Midrash quotes is the law of a pledge given for a loan. Their souls were a pledge. It is a reading for the month of Chanukah, when we remember those who would not bow to the decrees.

The soul held in trust

A third reading in the Midrash turns to the soul as a deposit.

בנוהג שבעולם אדם מפקידין אצלו פקדונות והוא מחליף את של זה בזה ואת של זה בזה. אבל הקב"ה אינו כן אלא (ירמיה י י) וה' אלקים אמת

In the way of the world, people deposit things with a man, and he mixes up this one's with that one's. But the Holy One, blessed be He, is not so, but "the L-rd is truly G-d" (Yirmiyahu 10:10). Did anyone ever rise in the morning and seek his soul and not find it, or find his soul in another's hand, or another's soul in his? Therefore: "the L-rd is truly G-d."

Midrash Tehillim 25

Every night we hand our souls to G-d, and every morning He returns them, each to its owner, without mixing them up. The Midrash brings a verse from Tehillim 31, "Into Your hand I entrust my spirit," the verse that Abaye, in the Gemara, names as a verse of mercy to say on one's bed at night (Berachos 5a). "To You I lift my soul" is the same act: handing the soul over and trusting that it will be kept.

The companion booklet on Tehillim 1–9 read "Safe and sound, I lie down and sleep" as the sleep of trust. This Midrash adds a picture of what happens in that sleep. The soul is on deposit with the only Keeper who never confuses one person's life with another's.

Toldos: lifting the soul to a blessing

This week's parashah is full of people lifting their souls toward something. Esav lifted his soul to a bowl of stew and sold his birthright. Yitzchak lifted his soul toward a meal and a blessing. Rivkah lifted hers toward the prophecy she had received, "the older shall serve the younger." Yaakov, at his mother's word, risked a curse to receive the blessing. The

psalm asks the question beneath all of them: toward what do you lift your soul? Its own answer is the first word, eilecha: “to You.”

For the table

1. The Malbim says everything else we ask for is a means, and G-d is the goal. What would change if you prayed that way?
2. The Midrash compares us to a worker waiting for his wage. Does that image comfort you or challenge you?
3. Every night we hand our souls over; every morning they are returned. What does it mean to wake up as a returned deposit?
4. Toward what do you lift your soul most often in a day?

Appendix A. Tehillim 25 in full

Hebrew from the Sefaria Miqra text (vowels removed); English from Tanakh: The Holy Scriptures (Jewish Publication Society, 1985), via Sefaria, opened 11 November 2026, with divine names written G-d and L-rd and the Hebrew Divine Names replaced as explained in the note on sources.

1 לדוד אליך ה' נפשי אשא

Of David. O L-RD, I set my hope on You;

2 אלקי בך בטחתי אל־אבושה אל־יעלצו אויבי לי

my G-d, in You I trust; may I not be disappointed, may my enemies not exult over me.

3 גם כל־קויך לא יבשו יבשו הבוגדים ריקם

O let none who look to You be disappointed; let the faithless be disappointed, empty-handed.

4 דרכיך ה' הודיעני ארחותיך למדני

Let me know Your paths, O L-RD; teach me Your ways;

5 הדריכני באמתך ולמדני כי־אתה אלקי ישעי אותך קויתי כל־היום

guide me in Your true way and teach me, for You are G-d, my deliverer; it is You I look to at all times.

6 זכר־רחמיך ה' וחסדיך כי מעולם המה

O L-RD, be mindful of Your compassion and Your faithfulness; they are old as time.

7 חטאות נעורי ופשעי אל־תזכר כחסדך זכר־לי־אתה למען טובך ה'

Be not mindful of my youthful sins and transgressions; in keeping with Your faithfulness consider what is in my favor, as befits Your goodness, O L-RD.

8 טוב־וישר ה' על־כן יורה חטאים בדרך

Good and upright is the L-RD; therefore He shows sinners the way.

9 ידרך ענוים במשפט וילמד ענוים דרכו

He guides the lowly in the right path, and teaches the lowly His way.

10 כל־ארחות ה' חסד ואמת לנצרי בריתו ועדתיו

All the L-RD's paths are steadfast love for those who keep the decrees of His covenant.

11 למען־שמך ה' וסלחת לעוני כי רב־הוא

As befits Your name, O L-RD, pardon my iniquity though it be great.

12 מי־זה האיש ירא ה' יורנו בדרך יבחר

Whoever fears the L-RD, he shall be shown what path to choose.

13 נפשו בטוב תלין וזרעו יירש ארץ

He shall live a happy life, and his children shall inherit the land.

14 סוד ה' ליראיו ובריתו להודיעם

The counsel of the L-RD is for those who fear Him; to them He makes known His covenant.

15 עיני תמיד אל־ה' כי הוא־יוציא מרשת רגלי

My eyes are ever toward the L-RD, for He will loose my feet from the net.

16 פנה־אלי וחנני כי־יחיד ועני אני

Turn to me, have mercy on me, for I am alone and afflicted.

17 צרות לבבי הרחיבו ממצוקותי הוציאני

My deep distress increases; deliver me from my straits.

18 ראה עניי ועמלי ושא לכל־חטאותי

Look at my affliction and suffering, and forgive all my sins.

19 ראה־איבי כי־רבו ושנאת חמס שנאוני

See how numerous my enemies are, and how unjustly they hate me!

20 שמרה נפשי והצילני אל־אבוש כי־חסיתי בך

Protect me and save me; let me not be disappointed, for I have sought refuge in You.

21 תם־וישר יצרוני כי קויתיך

May integrity and uprightness watch over me, for I look to You.

22 פדה אלקים את־ישראל מכל צרותיו

O G-d, redeem Israel from all its distress.

Glossary

Anavim. The humble or lowly (Tehillim 25:9).

Bitachon. Trust in G-d.

Chesed ve'emes. Kindness and truth (Tehillim 25:10).

Cities of refuge. Cities to which one who killed by accident could flee (Bamidbar 35; Devarim 19).

Derech, orach. Way and path; the Malbim distinguishes the highway from the side path.

Ibn Ezra. Rabbi Avraham ibn Ezra (1089–1167), grammarian, poet and commentator.

Kav, kivisi. Hope; from the root k-v-h, a cord stretched taut.

Kesel. Trust; from the root k-s-l, which gives the name of the month Kislev.

Malbim. Rabbi Meir Leibush Weiser (1809–1879), commentator on all of Tanach.

Metzudas David. Commentary by Rabbi David Altschuler and his son Rabbi Yechiel Hillel (eighteenth century).

Midrash Tehillim. The classical midrash on Tehillim, also called Shocher Tov.

Pesha, chet, avon. Transgression (rebellion), sin (error) and iniquity.

Radak. Rabbi David Kimchi (1160–1235), grammarian and commentator, of Narbonne.

Rashi. Rabbi Shlomo Yitzchaki (1040–1105), the foremost commentator on Tanach and Talmud.

Sinas chinam. Hatred without cause.

Sod. Secret, counsel, intimacy (Tehillim 25:14).

Thirteen Attributes. The attributes of mercy revealed to Moshe (Shemos 34:6–7).

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Thorne Toren, Aryeh Leib. *Tehillim 1–9: The First Day*. Study booklet, 11 November 2026.

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